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John LaBarbera

John LaBarbera's compositions and arrangements have been performed by Buddy Rich, Woody Herman, Count Basie, and the Glenn Miller Orchestra. His scoring credits include TV and radio spots for Kodak and Xerox; and his published charts are considered standards in the field of jazz education.

John was interviewed via Zoom on July 13, 2021 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe for the Fillius Jazz Archive at Hamilton College. I'm very pleased to have John LaBarbera with me today. I'm going to introduce you as first a fourth trumpeter, composer/arranger, and I'm very glad to have you here because I love talking about composing and arranging.

JL: Well thanks, Monk. I've watched your interviews with a number of folks, including my brother Pat, and you know, I really enjoy being a part of this. Really.

MR: Excellent. I'm not going to spend a lot of time on this but I had a couple of thoughts and questions about the family band. For those of you who might be watching we have three brothers and your father and mother were also in the group. Is that correct?

JL: Yes that's right.

MR: And how old were you during the years that this band was active?

JL: I think I started when I was six or seven. If Pat was eight then I was six. And Joe would have been, oh no, I think I was seven and Joe was five, or four. I'm sorry. Joe was four or five. Somewhere along in that line. It's hard to remember because we were always playing. The family band came much — but my mother at first was not part of the band as you probably know from Pat. But I think when I was about eight we were gigging steadily as a family band.

MR: Did your father write parts for your trumpet playing that — with the fact that you're seven or eight?

JL: No, no. We just played stock arrangements. We didn't ease into it. I mean they weren't that difficult, the stocks weren't that difficult but we started right out playing stocks. He wrote some polka things out that — he would transcribe some polka parts for the trumpet that were originally for me, and he made the clarinet or mandolin — Pat would play clarinet and I would play, well during those — when we played the polkas I played piano most of the time. But he would copy some parts, yeah, for trumpet, but not a lot.

MR: For the folks who don't know, can you explain what stocks means?

JL: Oh, well, these were dance band arrangements. They were called convertible arrangements. I called them contemptible, contemptible, but anyway these arrangements

were written for a typical society dance band which included violin; piano, bass and drums; saxophones, so you would have your first alto, your second tenor, and the third part would be baritone sometimes. All right? And two trumpets and one trombone. Usually. And they were expandable, also expendable. So you could play them with a trumpet and an alto saxophone, first trumpet and first alto, and rhythm section, and they would sound. But then you could add all those other instruments and they'd sound fuller. And this is the type of arranging that we used to use for the Catskill Mountain singers you know, they want to play it with a trio and a full big band. It's got to be expandable. And it's a certain technique that was — Spud Murphy, Johnny Warrington, all those guys could write these things, Van Alexander. And they were quite popular. And my father, we would go every week to Rochester, New York to Levitt's Music and he would buy more stocks, whatever the popular tune was, and we'd play it. I've got them all in my garage.

MR: No kidding.

JL: Oh yeah. Hundreds.

MR: So in the future you can have another band playing the stocks. I remember seeing those names you mentioned in junior high, we called it the stage band.

JL: Yeah. You had to call it the stage band, yeah.

MR: Now there is a certain skill I guess, a formulatic skill to writing in that fashion. I'm wondering, I looked up just before we joined today some of the top popular songs in 1957. So would you get requests, people coming up to the band and saying, "Hey, can you play 'Raunchy' or can you play 'Sleepwalk' or how about some Elvis Presley?"

JL: We would get that occasionally but it was rare. It was rare for the clientele that we were playing for. I think we had a couple of rock & roll things that were, you know, popular, also the "Hucklebuck," you know popular dance kind of things. But nothing really current for that period. I mean you have to remember that also in that period people were singing "Oh My Papa" and things like that were in parallel universe with the Elvis Presleys and the others.

MR: That's a terrific way to say that and I've been fascinated by that, because when you look at the top ten from a particular month and week in the mid-50s you see exactly that. Mitch Miller followed by Elvis or the other way around. It's really fascinating.

JL: Yeah. And you remember the Hit Parade of course, that would give you the top ten or top fifteen. Well Pop also bought these books. They were combo books called "Combo Orks."

MR: Combo Orks.

JL: And they would have like the hit tunes and it was a cheap and dirty way of you know playing with a small band and covering those. So we would have a whole pile of music

with us and if someone had a request and we had it, bam, we'd come out and we'd play it. It was good training.

MR: Let's suppose you had a week in the summer and you played three gigs. What kind of money would you expect from your father, individually?

JL: Originally I think we got three dollars, then it went up to five dollars. You know we were buying our own comic books when we were in school and we had more money than anybody in my class. Because you remember, five bucks back in the 50s was a considerable allowance. Most kids were getting 25 cents or 50 cents as an allowance if they got an allowance.

MR: Do you remember if at some point, you mentioned the stock arrangements, and you're playing all this different music. Did you have this epiphany or an aha moment, like I could do this? I could arrange. I want to do that.

JL: Well I don't know if it really was an epiphany moment but I remember when we started getting interested in jazz, real jazz, not the Dixieland or the swing stuff that we were playing as kids, when we got into high school and we all of a sudden heard Miles Davis and we heard all of these great artists, I was the one who took them off the records. I have, for some reason I have the ability to hear all those inner lines and then write them down. I was the one who did that. So we could copy "So What" you know the Miles Davis group with the three horns or two horns, and I would copy all the notes off and write them out. So I was in the habit of doing that. But really we didn't listen to big bands at all. I mean not at all, but we listened to some Glenn Miller and stuff like that, Stan Kenton. But I really didn't get into big bands until I got into college, when I heard, you know, toward the end of my senior year I started hearing "Woody Herman '63" and we saw Woody Herman's band live, and "Maynard '61," all those bands and it really had a big effect on me for some reason, it just grabbed me, and maybe because I had the ability to hear some of that inner stuff then I gravitated toward that kind of writing, although originally it was all small bands for us.

MR: Was your father, I'm not sure how to put this, was he living out a way of life that he wished he had had as a professional musician?

JL: Could be. It's very possible. Because you know he never had a childhood and he made sure that we had a real childhood and really had a family unit, which, you know, he was in an orphanage for a while so he made sure that we were in a good family unit and he told me that when he had three sons, you know that was a big deal having three sons, originally, because he did all kinds of carpentry and odd jobs. He figured he could have his own construction company with three boys, three sons, you could really do well. But he also gave us the music. So you know he didn't have money so basically he gave us that opportunity. And you've got to remember, being a musician back then was not a real

job. No one thought you could make a living doing that. But he made sure that we had that foundation. Of course then when we went off on our own and started playing without the family band, you know, we were making money and gigging so I think he was kind of pleased about that. And I'm sure he would have loved to have been a professional out in the real world, out in the world, but he had so many bands in the area. He had marching bands, he had concert bands, dance bands, you name it. So he had bands for every occasion. When Mussolini's brown shirts came to Mount Morris, he called ahead and found "Giovinezza" which was the theme song from Mussolini's youth, the youth, Giovinezza, the youth. And when the brown shirts were marching down the street of Mount Morris he had the band start playing that and they were shocked and they gave the old salute to Mussolini. They were staying in Dansville at the McFadden mansion. He was a real right winger. I don't know if you remember that.

MR: I do — that's the first I've heard about brown shirts anywhere in New York State.

JL: Yeah, was it the brown shirts or the black shirts? I think it was the brown shirts. Whatever Mussolini's youth group was. And this McFadden had a huge resort in Dansville, kind of a weird medical kind of a colon-cleansing and all that, he invited them to the United States before we got involved and all that. But Pop was always on top of things. He had that theme song. I've probably got it out in the garage. But no one even knew what that was.

MR: What finally, everybody got older and was there a particular thing that caused the family band to go the way of all bands, eventually it has to end somewhere.

JL: Well we were getting more into jazz and we were in high school, and we didn't have the kind of time when we were in grade school to go out and gig all the time. Plus I think my parents were happy to have some time alone at home and get rid of the kids, get us out the door.

MR: What role did your Italian heritage have in this whole thing? I noticed that you were written about in a new book about jazz musicians and the Italian heritage.

JL: Well you know we were, we were in a town that was mostly Irish American and we were the Sicilians. And we were pretty low on the totem pole. But it wasn't in your face every day, because our group was pretty much among our ethnic neighbors and family. But you know the Italian thing I never really thought about it until I got into college. I didn't know I was Italian until I got to college and someone called me a name. You know really, because we never thought about that. Everybody had a name like ours in our town except for the others, the other side. And I'm not being jive about this but I really didn't think about that race thing because we weren't raised as, you've got to remember my father came from Sicily so the racism was not bare, fundamentally there was nothing there. But when I got to college, well you meet all kinds of people in college and, you know, we

were talking about Hal, that's where I first met Hal. I think he was the very first black friend I've ever had in my life. Because in Mount Morris I think there was one black family. I think. Yeah, there was one black family in Mount Morris. Yeah.

MR: What would have happened, I think Pat said that he gave me a little anecdote and he discovered improvising because he couldn't see the music to play the written out solo.

JL: Yeah the Ted Mack Amateur Hour audition — or there was a contest at one of the — I can't remember what it was but it was at a county fair and they had a contest and we entered it. And Pat, I guess the music either blew away or he couldn't see it. And he had that — that was an epiphany because he made it up. And then we realized that that was a thing. But you know there was no books, there were no books at that period like you can get today. So we would try to copy — we didn't try we did, we copied solos off the record and then we'd take Pop's fake books and see what the chord changes were, which were very poor changes, and try to figure out why did Lee Morgan play that E flat on a C 7 chord. It's like what is this?

MR: You were doing like second year jazz education. I mean that is such great ear training to discover that on your own.

JL: Yeah it is. Because again, I mean they had these books like hot jazz solos that were written out, you know, make believe solos by somebody and Charlie Colin, Charles Colin used to publish those, and those were a rarity. I mean we'd get our hands on those it'd be nice. But they really didn't give you, they were pretty diatonic. They didn't give you the real deal. You know you hear Miles Davis play on some of these tunes, even on a blues, you know what was that all about? You know your ears think wow, it works but why?

MR: Yes. And if I play the same thing is it going to work as well as that.

JL: And we all copied solos. Pat's still got all the solos in books that he copied. But that's the way you learn. You have to learn by copying and then hopefully your own thing comes out.

MR: Do you feel like you developed your own thing on the trumpet?

JL: No not really. I think I had up to about some great Lee Morgan licks up until the 60s. But you know trumpet was a way of staying in music and making some money, but I really didn't have that fire like Pat has or Joe has for the instrument. Because when writing took over, I really didn't, you know I've got a trumpet back there somewhere but you know it's not my passion. I like playing it, it's fun. But I really didn't have that fire to continue on like Pat did and really get into it. Because again, the writing took over.

MR: So you became a writer, you're dependent on whether people play your music.

JL: Yup.

MR: How do you — what was your entrance like into that world?

JL: Well Buddy Rich of course put me on the map. You know I played trumpet on Buddy's band for about four months. He fired me a couple of times, at least a couple of times. But I learned a lot on that band. Of course playing in bands, like with my parents with our family band, you understand how things work. You hear the melody then you hear the counter line. And when I was playing in college, when I played in big bands in college, I had my own big band in Potsdam. Well you get to hear all those inner voicings and inner workings. And that's why single line instrumentalists make the best arrangers. Piano players and guitar players are the hardest people to teach. But a single line instrument — let me put it this way — a non-breathing player, a non-breathing instrument player has the hardest time writing, because they don't have to breathe. But a horn player or a wind player, put it that way, are the people who really get it quickly. You know like Billy Byers and Slide Hampton, we can go right down — Bill Holman, go right down on the list. But I forgot where we were going with this.

MR: Well I wondered how you, like if there was a real door that opened you, for your composing and I think you said Buddy Rich because you came back and started writing for him, is that correct?

JL: Yes. I enjoyed the band. You know he respected me and if he respected you he would take a chance on you — if he respected you as a player he'd take a chance on you as a writer. That's why a lot of the guys in the band were writing charts for the band, because he respected their playing and he would listen to what they had to write. Well I was on the Glenn Miller band for three years, almost three years with Buddy DeFranco. And I learned a lot from him as well. So all the time I was on the Glenn Miller band I was writing arrangements, I was transcribing the Miller stuff off the 78 recordings, because a lot of that music disappeared. The real arrangements disappeared. And a lot — I mean we had the library in New York City which I'd go through, all the Bill Finegan stuff, but a lot of times I was transcribing from a 78 recording on a cassette tape in the back of the bus. Anyway, so I made all my mistakes on the Glenn Miller band. And then we were in England on tour and I said I can't do this. Because I looked across the aisle at an alto player named, oh God, why can't I think of his name, it'll come back to me. He'd been on the band with every road band there was, Al Thompson. He was a second alto player. He played in every band and that's all he did. He was an alcoholic and I looked across and I said that could be me, you know, at the end of my life just sitting there on the damn band bus, you know, playing one-nighters. So I gave my notice in England and I was back in Rochester on unemployment. A lot of people helped us out like for instance Vince Falcone who was Frank Sinatra's accompanist. He ran a piano company, the Shale Piano Company in Rochester. And he would give us the pianos the people traded in. He gave Chuck Mangione one, he gave Pat one, he gave me one. He'd have the guys deliver

it to your apartment, because you know it's not worth anything, it's just like a used car, they'll give you so much for the trade in. Anyway, long story short, I was on unemployment and I heard that Buddy had signed, Pat told me that Buddy had signed with RCA Victor. And so I was making fifty bucks a week on unemployment and then doing odd jobs. A bus trip to Philadelphia was 25 bucks. So I bought a bus ticket to Philadelphia with this "Piece of the Road" suite that I wrote. And everybody was there at the club, Brandy's Wharf in Philadelphia. You know Don Sebesky, all the guys were there with charts. So it was a cattle call. So I was there, put on the chart down, I've actually got a cassette of the rehearsal, and you know Buddy didn't play he just sat there. And there was a, they started with a ballad which was unusual for Jimmy Mosher, and then there was a rock piece, and then a solo piano and then a jazz waltz. When we got to the jazz waltz part, after about, I don't know maybe about half the chart, maybe not even half the chart, he stopped. And he went and sat down at the drums and played it. And at the end he says, "Okay, I want you in New York in a couple of weeks and we're going to record your stuff." Just like that. And you know I said, "Yeah, sure, right." You know. But that was it. He said, "You're in." And you know I've told this story before but that really put me on the map, writing for Buddy Rich. I mean you can't get any bigger than that.

MR: Man, I bet your made sure that the parts were all correct. I mean did you do the copying by yourself at that time?

JL: You would think I would do that. You would think I would make all kinds of painful reviewing. But luckily a lot of the guys in the band were my friends and they corrected a lot of mistakes for me. The parts were in pencil. The parts were in pencil. However, when we finally got to the RCA Victor recording, this was in the old days when the record companies paid for the copyist, they paid the composer and the arranger, everything was union scale. So I was on the road with a man named Milt Newman who had worked as a copyist. He taught me how to copy. But then I befriended a good colleague of his, Larry Abel, who became my copyist for years. And he did all the copying and it was all done you know, the right way, and the record company paid for it. The copyist got residuals.

MR: Oh no kidding?

JL: Yeah.

MR: Wow. What did you expect from him? Did you trust him to come to you and say, "Listen John, measure 46 you've got this note that, I don't think it's what you want. Would he do that?

JL: No he would just say something's wrong there. Or I don't like that section cut it out. And you'd have to do it. It's like Mancini said, it's like giving up one of your children but you

have to do it, you can't fall in love with every note you write. Because he knows more than you do about what he's presenting.

MR: Wow.

JL: Yeah.

MR: He hadn't heard it yet.

JL: No.

MR: But he could tell by looking at it.

JL: He could tell by hearing it. You know we rehearsed the whole thing. He couldn't read music but he must have had this second sense of the whole picture. For instance you know my CD "On the Wild Side" I recorded "Walk on the Wild Side" the whole suite. I wrote that for Buddy. And he played it but he never got to record it before he died. And when I brought it into him there's a Dixieland section in there that Elmer Bernstein had in the film. He cut the entire thing out. And I was pissed. But it works that way and so when I recorded it myself I did it the way he wanted it. Because he could tell what the — you know he could tell, all right, by this point the audience is getting itchy. They're going to want the drum solo, they're going to want something big. You can't drag it on after a ballad and have a Dixieland thing. Or whatever. You know, that kind of sense.

MR: Did you ever write a Buddy Rich chart that didn't have a drum solo that he said, "Okay we've got to put in a drum solo."

JL: Never. And I did a lot of things that weren't drum solos and he liked them. See one thing about writing for Buddy Rich, I wrote for — I've written for the other bands, Buddy did not have a style. People could argue that he did, but he didn't have a style. You could bring any kind of chart into Buddy and he would try it. He may not like it, he may not use it, but he had a voracious appetite for new material. That's — my brother Pat hipped me to the fact that never bring anything in two weeks or two months or three months before the recording session. Bring it in at the last minute because he's tired of that other stuff, he wants new stuff. And for subsequent records I did that, I brought in, you know we were going to record in London and two weeks before we went to London I brought in all that stuff and he said, "All right, let's go to London and record it."

MR: So that would get played live maybe a few times before the session. But not too many times.

JL: Yes. Not too many times, because again, he'd get bored. And although he did have his favorites and he had things he had to play like "West Side Story" or "Channel One Suite," things the audience expected. Like Woody Herman had to play "Woodchopper's Ball." You had your little hits and you had to make sure you fulfilled that requirement for the audience.

MR: I wonder if you had a feeling and other composer/arrangers have this feeling that I'm writing this chart for Buddy Rich but I want it to be something that other bands will want to play or that I can market to the educational field, and how do I walk that line?

JL: I couldn't think that way because the stuff that I'd write for Buddy Rich would be too hard for college bands and high school bands to play. And there really wasn't a market for real professional charts. So when you talk about Hal Leonard or Kendor or any of the publishing companies, they had a level of proficiency that they stuck with for colleges and for high schools. A grade level. Now some of the things that I ended up publishing were kind of scaled down for that market, when I finally did decide to start selling them in the, you know, educational field. But I always, when I was writing for the band I was writing for that band, I wasn't going to short-change it and try and water it down so it had a second level of, you know, commerciality.

MR: Did you have a way of determining a price for your work and how did it change over the years?

JL: That's a rough one. That is hard. Because you never know what to charge. You know the worst thing you can hear a producer say is, "Thank you for being so reasonable." That's the last thing you want to hear. You know what? You get a sense of what the bandleader or the client can pay. You get a sense, and you hit them with a figure. And you just hope they will come back with something, or they don't say get lost. It's hard. Because you know every market is different. Like for Buddy Rich a lot of people don't know this but I rarely got paid by Buddy. A lot of stuff I had to scream and yell trying to get paid. He didn't have the money. He was used to, as a star, having anything he wanted. He just would spend — I'll buy this — and a lot of times the manager didn't have the money to pay me. And when I had friends that were managers, like Stanley Kay, he would go to bat for me, he'd find the money somewhere. He'd maybe take an extra couple of hundred here. But having said that, Buddy gave me all of the publishing rights to everything I had done for him. He knew, he knew that was a valuable thing. Woody Herman didn't. Maynard Ferguson didn't. Count Basie didn't. They would grab the publishing, as rightfully they should. Buddy gave me a hundred percent of everything. So that was the payback. It was rough at the time but you know, the payback is there.

MR: Did you ever have a manager or bandleader say, "Come on, John, this would be good exposure for you"?

JL: Yeah. I had that happen. I had a record company out in California, one of Woody's recordings. The guy said, "Well we don't pay that kind of money for arrangements" and you know, "this is something you should be happy, you're going to get your stuff on a Woody Herman record." Yeah. I've got stories. There's a lot of stories out there.

MR: You mentioned your stint with Glenn Miller and you made your arranging mistakes then. What were the arranging mistakes that you learned about and didn't do later?

JL: Writing too much. Just writing everything. You know I'll back up and say that the first symphony I heard was at Geneseo State Teacher's College. My father and mother took us to see an orchestra, the Rochester Symphony. And I'd never heard anything like that in my life. And I hadn't heard a real full big band at that point either, right? You know that was the first large ensemble live that I heard. You know in high school we had concert bands and all that. But anyway, when they took a break I looked at the stage and I could hear all of those instruments, just looking at the music stands. Now it sounds kind of stupid but when I first went on Buddy's band and I would sit there and in the band itself that didn't happen. But when I stood in front of a band, or sat in front of a band, and the band took a break, if I looked at the music stands I could hear all the music. Now I don't need to look at the music stands, I found, with the Glenn Miller band, that you know I can hear the whole package. But the problem is is that you don't have the experience of editing. I think maybe Bill Holman said it, you know, you write all your life and toward the end of your career you learn how to take stuff away, how to not put it down in the first place, how to not write. So I was writing too busily and too much stuff. And of course Buddy DeFranco would give me criticisms and comments like that because he worked with everybody. And a lot of it took hold. And then by studying the Glenn Miller scores, like Bill Finegan's scores and stuff like that, I learned a lot. Space is very important.

MR: Yes. If you look at a score and everybody's playing all the time, you have trouble. But I know in the past I've had instances where I look at a score I've written and, especially if it's for a large group, and, "Gee I haven't written anything for the bassoon in 20 measures, I'd better give him something to do." And that is not really the way to think I guess.

JL: No. Not at all. You have to think in colors and combinations. You know with the jazz big band you think you'd run out of colors but you don't. You can always find new combinations. You could never use up all the devices.

MR: It's interesting you say that because I listened to one of your charts last night of your own band, and I jotted the name down and now I can't find it, but it was like a swing chart and you had one trumpet player playing the melody with the sax section. And it was such a great effect. It was not totally obvious but it changed the sound of the melody. That was really cool.

JL: Yeah I stole that from Thad Jones. Yeah Thad would always couple the flugelhorn with the lead alto and/or if the lead melody line in the saxes is a soprano sax, which is a very weak instrument, then he would couple the flugelhorn with the soprano in the melody and

it worked very well. Bill Stapleton, with Woody Herman's band, he did that, he stole that from Thad too. We all stole from each other. But it's interesting that if you couple things correctly, and it was a compliment you just paid me, that you can't tell what it is, you just hear — it's in there. You know.

MR: Yeah. It's a unique sound for that time. You must have transitioned, well I should say and ask, do you now use software, Finale or Sibelius or whatever?

JL: Yeah I use Finale only because I can extract the parts. I hate copying parts. I can write faster with a score pad and pencil. I think Gordon Goodwin can as well and Mark Taylor as well. But after you've got the sketch done, for me now once I've got it in my head I just put it down in the computer and then you can extract the parts. Because that's the hardest part is writing out the parts.

MR: That's for sure. But can you tell if using Finale has changed the way you write?

JL: No it hasn't. As a matter of fact when I was teaching, I just retired a few years ago, I would make it a point to all my students that you cannot use the playback of Finale or Sibelius or any of those. Do not listen to the playback. If you listen to a playback make everything *piano*. Because you're going to get fooled because the instrument has no overtones. I've put in, just as an example for the kids, I've put in Thad Jones's "Quietitude" I put that in Finale, I put in Gil Evans's "My Ship," I put that in Finale. And I've got the best sound libraries you can buy. All right? And I play it back to the kids. It sounds like crap. You wouldn't dare write that, because that doesn't sound right. And they hear the sounds, "Oh that's not right" so they take it away. They're afraid to put the sharp nine and the natural nine together, you know, in a dominant seven chord because the machine doesn't like it you know. It sounds awful. So they won't take a chance. And that's the one thing I really pounded into their heads that you cannot do that. And no it doesn't affect me but it might affect younger writers today. They might, you know, take the easy way out because the machine tells them that, or the sounds.

MR: Plus the opportunities to sit in a big band and absorb all that information over the years is not there like it was unless you're in an educational school —

JL: Yep that's right. I really bemoan the fact that there aren't any bands for these kids to go out and get real training. I mean there's nothing like being in a band, whether it be a small band or a big band, but big band, learning how to play in a section, how to balance, you know, how to listen. It's really important.

MR: As time goes by and terrific arrangers come and go, does it become harder to create something new?

JL: Well yes, it does. You know you could fall into a trap very easily and copy your own style and it is hard to come up with something new. And you know you have to constantly listen. Now there was a period in the 60s and 70s where all of these different

styles of music were out there, and a lot of them, you know the bossa nova, sambas, all these things melded very well with jazz. Well today we don't have that variety of different cultures coming into jazz. Somebody will argue with me yes there are some European or world music things that have creeped in. But we don't have, you know we had the straight eighth stuff, we had the samba stuff, we had, you name it, all kinds of different styles of music that could be absorbed in jazz, Afro-Cuban, all that stuff. But today I don't see that wealth of other styles that can be melded into a large ensemble or into jazz. Now maybe I'm not listening as much as I used to, I probably don't listen as much as I used to, but you know I have the XM radio jazz station and I listen to other stations, and try to keep current. But it's hard to come up with something original when you don't have to. Put it this way, I don't have a deadline, I don't have a bandleader breathing down my neck, where's the chart, where's the chart. So that's an answer.

MR: Okay. There's a phrase the I heard from Dave Rivello, who said —

JL: Very good arranger.

MR: Said he heard it from Maria Schneider, who heard it from Bob Brookmeyer, okay? I'm tracing the lineage. And the statement was, from Brookmeyer, you should try to hold off as long as you can in an arrangement before you pass it to a soloist. So my question is do you agree with that, and the follow-up is have you ever felt like you want to give soloists some guidance for the way they're going to solo on this chart that you've spent many hours working on?

JL: Just the opposite. As a matter of fact I don't agree with Bobby. Bobby at one point made the statement that a jazz arrangement could be jazz without improvisation. The creative art of manipulating notes in a jazz style was enough without improvisation. To me the chart is just a vehicle. It's just a skeleton to get the improvisation out there. So my focus is the jazz improvisation. And like for instance when I wrote for — the very first album I had, Bud Shank on alto and Clay Jenkins on trumpet and I did a Horace Silver tune. Now in some way I guess I did do what you're asking about knowing that Bud Shank did not play in that same style as Clay Jenkins. I kept the alto solo changes to be very comparable to the style of bebop and post-bop that Bud Shank would play. And then, when I transitioned to the trumpet solo I went into the Coltrane modal changes that I knew that would be very comfortable for Clay. I guess in a way I did guide it there, but my real focus is I'm there for the soloist. That's the whole idea of the chart. If you listen to all my arrangements it is about the soloist, especially with my brothers.

MR: Yes, the one I was listening to last night, I think it was Clay playing on it. And he had a lot of space, as did the tenor player who followed him.

JL: Yeah, you know I wrote a chart for Buddy, we were in Boston at Lenny's on the Turnpike. It was "God Bless the Child." And I wrote it for Joe Romano, a great alto

player. You probably knew Joe, I'm sure. And so I wrote it in a day, because he wanted it the next night. And I brought it in and I really was pleased with it. And you know, in the second chorus there was nothing except the rhythm section and Joe, all that nice space. Because most soloists don't like backgrounds underneath them. They want that freedom to take it wherever they want to go. And then that night after the gig Buddy says, "Fill that in, I don't like that, it's too much open space, fill that in." And he made me put backgrounds in and that's the public arrangement that's out there now. But he wanted that filled in. He liked that have that fullness. I like to hear the space for the soloist. And when they're done then I'll bring the band back in.

MR: When you're in the middle of a chart are you obsessed with it?

JL: Yes. Yes I am. As a matter of fact I'm totally obsessed with it, and then you know your subconscious is always working on it, so when I go to sleep at night it's still working on that chart and when I get up in the morning I'll have an answer or I'll have something. I used to do that with TV commercials. I got so competent that I knew I had a jingle in the morning, I couldn't make it work for me at night so I would just go to sleep, wake up knowing that I would have the answer in the morning. Now this isn't rocket science and it isn't some famous symphonic work, this is a jingle. But your mind works on that stuff. It totally works on it. And there's always an answer.

MR: There's always an answer. I'm glad you moved on, you brought up jingles, because I wanted to spend a little time with that. It seems like another area of music that requires a certain approach, especially if it's background music. And did you find that difficult to get used to?

JL: Very difficult. Especially 60-second spots. You have to say it in 60 seconds but you also have to be able to cut that 60 down to 30 or a 20, or make it longer. I'll say one thing, I should point out that all the time I was writing jazz with, you know, two young boys, two children and a wife, the way you survive is writing whatever you can. And the jingles and the industrial videos and all that stuff saves your life. But — and you don't have to put your name on it. So it was a great way of supporting a family, but a lot of idiots out there, I mean the ignorance among the advertising agencies is incredible. The plop-plop-fizz-fizz, the Sammy Davis thing, that was a disaster. And you really have to think quickly on your feet. You really have to be sharp, and know all the different styles of music when you're writing jingles. You have to know all of the styles. I did Wegman's commercials for years, all of their commercials. And we had — I wrote the theme and then there was a Thanksgiving, there was an Easter, there was an October-fest and there was a — whatever season they were pushing, turkeys or whatever you know. And you would have to make it all work.

MR: Well the next time I go into Wegman's I'm going to say I know the guy who did all your commercials.

JL: Yeah I did them for years, yeah. It was a good run. It was a nice account to have it really was.

MR: So did you have occasion to be in the studio and the ad guy who thought he knew music was there and, "Okay John I want this to sound, you know, like the sun is coming up" and these vague descriptions and you're trying to find music?

JL: Yeah. I mean anyone who's done jingles has had that experience. Because they are there to look good to the client. And so they're trying to impress the client with their knowledge. Because they're charging them all this money. And all the guys in New York knew this. So I would go in and listen to what they had to say, "Oh you want more blue or your want it subtle here" and all that. So I'd go out to the guys and I'd say, "Now listen guys, we have to make it a little more" and I would just look at them and wink. They'd know I was bullshitting. And they'd play the same exact thing and he would say, "Yeah, that's it." Or she would say, "Yeah that's it." And the other trick was when they didn't like the mix, every engineer knows this trick, we give the producer a fader which did nothing. Now you say listen, I'll be controlling the horns here, when that sound that you don't, bring it down just a little bit." And it gave them something to look to the client and say see I'm important. And it never failed. Anyone who's done jingles could give you twenty stories like that.

MR: That's great. Do you get residuals for stuff that gets played again or played during certain events?

JL: I used to, yeah. When the union was strong in that realm and when synthesizers hadn't taken over yet, yes. You'd get residuals for whatever the run was and if they re-used it you'd get residuals again. Yeah. And the players did too. That was a great source of income for players.

MR: Yeah they would come in and do a 60-second spot and whatever, get a union wage for that?

JL: Yeah they'd do three a day. Steve Gadd was doing double scale, three a day. I mean I think he had checks at the union he never bothered to pick up. Have you interviewed Steve at all?

MR: I've tried to get with him. But maybe I need a phone number from somebody. He came a long way from the Ted Mack Amateur Hour.

JL: Yeah well now that was the Mickey Mouse Club when he —

MR: Oh the Mickey Mouse Club.

JL: We were at Sibley's audition — this was for the big Mickey Mouse Club contest, and Steve won because he could tap dance and play drums. I'll never forgive him for that.

No, my father went up to — I forgot the guy's name, who was the celebrity that died? Dean? Not Dean. Anyway Pop went up to him and said, "How come you chose him?" He says, "Well he could tap dance too. Your kids don't tap dance, they could just play music."

MR: Well I guess you're lucky that your father didn't, you know, call a rehearsal and say, "Okay fellas, I've got tap shoes for ya."

JL: No he made us go take dance lessons.

MR: He did?

JL: Oh yeah, we had to go take tap dance lessons after that. It didn't last very long, I couldn't stand it.

MR: So a while back I watched, it was a pretty good documentary on Quincy Jones. But I was disappointed that no one asked him where do your arranging ideas come from. It was mostly just people saying, you know, how great he was and his whole resume, which is incredible. So my question to you is, can you tell me where your arranging ideas, how do they occur to you?

JL: The song does it. You take the song that you're arranging and that tells you everything. It gives you everything you need. It really does. You know you can change — rhythmically or harmonically you've got all the material to work with. And every now — well maybe it's just the talent, but I'll go through, first of all I play through the song and listen to it, and then something will spring out, like oh here's a good introduction or here's a good shout chorus or you know, something in that melody, because that's what you're working with, something in that melody will trigger something and then the brain starts taking over. Mancini was that way too. He said that the melody is the thing. Everything is unimportant but it's the melody that we have to support. And he was a smart guy.

MR: If I propose to you, I'm going to commission you and money is no object but I want you to do a new take on "In the Mood."

JL: I probably wouldn't take the job. I might though, I might, depending on the band it was for and the musicianship of the band. I would do that, yeah I think I could pull that off. You know it's such a recognizable piece of music that it's hard to touch it. You know what I mean? It'd be like taking Miles Davis's "So What" and screwing it up somehow. No, that's not a good analogy. But anyway, these are certain sacred things that you have a hard time convincing the public they want to hear another version.

MR: Actually I recall now that I said that, that there was a disco version of it.

JL: Could be. Could be, yeah. I bet it was very successful too.

MR: I think it was. It was a whole big band on the disco dance floor.

JL: Um hum.

MR: I wanted to follow-up on something you just touched on about ownership. And you've done a lot of work in the field of intellectual property. Does the field and the guidelines and the way things work keep getting more complicated?

JL: Extremely complicated. Yes. One of the whole digital rights movement and the very quick changeover to the distribution model of music now is very complicated. There's just been a big reorganization of the mechanical rights organizations forming a consortium with the government's permission. Things are changing very very quickly because you no longer have the physical control of the product. Record companies have no control. Individuals have no control. So it's getting more and more difficult to identify what is an infringement. When it was a CD or an LP or a cassette or a video or whatever, there are certain licenses and certain revenue streams that you could follow. Now I know guys that are getting royalty checks for ten cents for two million plays on Spotify, or something like that — that's an exaggeration, but these corporations have taken over and they've belittled the quality and the importance of music to everybody, so now it's the climb back to fight back to say music is important and you should not minimalize its importance. Yeah, there's some — I think Maria Schneider's last CD was a finger point at all of the digital lords out there. I don't know if you've heard it. It's called "The Digital Lords." It's two CDs or something like that. But she's pointing fingers at these large corporations that are, you know, living on the backs of creative artists.

MR: You said, oh she finger pointed at them. Is that what you said?

JL: Yeah, it's called— what's the name of the CD — she's got two CDs and one is about the — well I don't want to put words in her mouth, but basically she is condemning the digital lords who are out there, like the Spotifys and all that. And I'm sure there's articles — I haven't seen any but I'm sure she's got some articles explaining that — I've got the CD in the other room I've played it on my radio show, but it's a very intense piece of music, the whole package. It's very intense.

MR: Yeah, speaking of when I asked a question about something new I think she found a way to add a new thing to the big band repertoire it seems like.

JL: Yeah. She studied with Rayburn Wright, who I also studied with, but I think she really found her groove when she studied with Bobby Brookmeyer and Gil Evans, when she started listening to them and studying with them. That really helped her a lot. And I think it reinforced her whole body of work. She probably had that diatonic sense she has today back then but I think they really molded it for her.

MR: Yeah she told me this, I won't get off on a tangent here, this will only take a second but it was a very interesting thing when she went to college and she wrote a piano — a piece for two pianos, that the professors laughed at it quietly because it was in a key.

JL: Yeah.

MR: And everybody was into atonality at the time.

JL: Oh yeah, and still are. Well you remember the old Sid Caesar bit when he was Progress Hornsby and he had the radar antenna on the bell of his tenor, and that's in case he got too close to the melody.

MR: Oh that's good. I wasn't aware of that.

JL: Oh Progress Hornsby, you know as kids we didn't have any place to go to see jazz, but once in a while there'd be a jazz reference on television like Sid Caesar doing Progress Hornsby. You know we were hungry for anything that, you know, related to jazz. And there was nothing on TV. Then Peter Gunn came out and boy that was an explosion right there.

MR: Isn't that interesting that when you compare it nowadays to everything is available at any time, how much joy we took in those discoveries.

JL: That's right.

MR: And that they came in few and far between, or spending hours listening to the record, to the radio, hoping they'll play that song again.

JL: Yeah. You know I still hear things and I think wow, what could they do there. You know I'll hear it once on the radio and then try to find it so I can try and figure out what they did. There's some really good, there's some talented people out there playing and writing. There's no question about it.

MR: Speaking of talent, the students that you've had when you were in academia, did you have any advice for them when they were about to graduate to help them enter the music world?

JL: Not unless they really asked, but you know you could tell the sincerity of a student after working with them for a couple of years. And if they had, if they said, "I want to write music for a living" then I would give them the advice, you have to go where the food is, you have to go to Los Angeles or go to New York or go to London or Toronto, but you have to go where the writing is important and where there is a living to be made writing. Now today yes you can do everything from a distance. But you're not going to get the work. You have to be out there schmoozing, you have to be visible. And a lot of clients, they don't want to know that you're a hundred miles away. They want to know that they can see you for lunch tomorrow and be there, and you know, those kinds of gigs. But I tell them, you go where the food is, and that's where it is.

MR: For you was that mostly New York and Los Angeles?

JL: Yeah. Mostly New York. Yeah. And that was — of course that was a different period. You know we got paid to do jingle demos. You got paid for the demo, and then they would like it, approve it, and then you'd get the full band. But those were different days. But New York was definitely a fertile ground. Today the only thing left in New York is

Broadway. I shouldn't make such a blanket statement but as far as the union is concerned the only thing for musicians today is Broadway.

MR: Did you ever do demos that turned out to be the record?

JL: Yeah. And a friend of mine, Jay Chattaway, he did an orchestra mock-up on synthesizers and they loved it and they used that instead of the full orchestra. It happens.

MR: What were the other things that happened that you sensed as a, uh oh, this seems like a musical, a big change in the scene, and how am I going to deal with this.

JL: That's when I left New York State and moved down here to teach at the University of Louisville. Everything was going south. I mean machines were replacing humans, even the jingles, people were doing them for free just to get the airplay, get the ASCAP airplay. Same out in California. Kids were doing TV themes and still are for nothing just to get the exposure and get the ASCAP, you know, or BMI airplay, performance royalties. So that's when I knew that it was time, it was definitely time. And they came after me so I says what the heck, why not.

MR: Okay. Health insurance.

JL: Yes. That's right, with two kids, health insurance. Plus I enjoyed teaching. I really enjoy teaching, and especially at the college level 'cause you've got a certain caliber of student that you can just jump in here and really bring them up. Yeah. I really enjoyed the teaching.

MR: Jumping back to our how we started, and I believe Pat told me that you guys never argued.

JL: No. Not really, no.

MR: If I got all of you on a four-person Zoom could I think of something that might make you argue together?

JL: Not really. We're pretty much on the same page. It was our upbringing, that Sicilian upbringing, the family is very close. But of course we're all in the same business and we all came up together listening to the same stuff, and we have similar political opinions and societal opinions. We talk every week if not more. And as I get closer to my next recording we'll be talking even more than that. But no we never argue. I mean we would punch each other or hit each other when we were kids, little kids, but no, we don't argue at all.

MR: As your careers were expanding did you ever get on the phone with them for advice about a decision you needed to make?

JL: Yeah, especially with Pat, 'cause Pat was the one who led us all. Pat was out there first. He was the trailblazer. You know I'm the middle, well-adjusted son. But he was the one who took all the blows. He's the one who got me on Buddy Rich's band you know. He, you know he would, I'd call him for some advice. Yup. And he's so knowledgeable. I'll

still call him about certain changes. I'll say, on this tune, actually I just did that recently 'cause we're doing a tune that he did with Elvin Jones. I'm doing it on my next recording. And I would call him and say what the hell is this, what is all this stuff. And of course he's got it all in his head. He's got all these tunes. And he would give me some ideas. Because not everything is consistent in, even in modal writing, nothing is that consistent and there's always something new to bridge, something new to discover. And when I hear something like that I'll call Pat and say what did he do here, what is that, if I can't figure it out myself.

MR: What do your piano parts look like?

JL: Well they're extremely well written. Because that's the discipline you get for writing for publishing. You know everything has to be written out. But now for my own recordings or for a professional band I'll only give certain things that I definitely want to have, and the rest is them because they, I mean anybody can write a better piano part than I can, but I can get the basic one down there. So when you're writing for school bands, colleges and high school, everything has to be written out, the bass line, the piano part. Now they can ignore that if they have the chops and the skills, but everything is written out. So my piano parts are very, very well written.

MR: Do you like to have keyboard and guitar in your own groups?

JL: No. No. They get in the way of each other. Although I will hand guitar on two pieces on my new recording as melodic instruments, not as a part of the rhythm section.

MR: Okay.

JL: Yeah I don't know, I mean Basie and Freddie Green is probably about it. I mean I don't know anybody else that can pull that off. But then they had their roles to play you know. Because Basie would just tinkle and Freddie would keep it going.

MR: When you get ready to do a recording like you've mentioned, do you always get the people you want?

JL: Yes. I try to anyway. You know I was all set to record last March or April, just before the pandemic. I had it all set up and you know there are certain people that I wanted and I called them and, 'cause I had certain people in mind for certain parts. And so you know I called well ahead of time. Now they could pull the plug at the last minute if they get a better call, you know like a film or something. But generally I get the people I want you know.

MR: Will they have seen the music before they get there?

JL: Never. No. You know you take players well like Pat, Wayne Bergeron, Bill Cunliffe, all those guys, you know, they don't need to see it in front. And when somebody wants the music in front I get a little suspicious.

MR: Oh that is a quote right there. Most of us don't live in that world, I can say.

JL: And you know even the best players, they're going to make mistakes and they say, ah, mistake, no big deal. I mean everybody does. But generally you know I like that insecurity of seeing it for the first time and having that fire and having that edge. There's an edge there. Clay Jenkins — talk about —

MR: It was interesting you mentioned the Basie rhythm section and I wonder, if you go to a festival with big bands, what is your feeling when you see a microphone in front of every instrument?

JL: Hate it. I hate it. You know you lose that natural balance of the ensemble. I can see tweaking the piano just a little bit, maybe one mic on the piano. But if you're going to play to microphones you're not going to have a normal balance of a big band. There's — Larry Wilcox, great arranger in New York, very few people know who he was, but he was a very good arranger. And he told me something that I'll never forget. He says when you write for any ensemble, especially orchestra, always write as if you're making it a live performance. Then when you get into the studio the mics are not as important. But if you write for the microphone you're never going to write a decent chart. And so that's the way you have to write and that's the way kids should listen when they're in a band. All these microphones, I don't get it.

MR: Could you explain that a little more? Don't write for the microphone?

JL: Yeah. For instance if you're not skilled enough to write for the flute along with the trumpets and along with the saxophones, if you don't know how to write a natural balance for those instruments well then it's not going to work. If you think, oh I'll put a mic on the flute and then it will work, that's not good orchestration. You can't. You can't think that way. So normally you would probably use three flutes along with one flugelhorn and one alto sax or one tenor more likely, to get the balance you want. So there's a physical — just like writing for strings. Exponentially they can go higher and higher the more numbers you have, but if you only have a few strings you can't go above A above the staff or B above the staff, because it thins out. So you have to know those natural balances and then work with them. Once you get into the studio then the rest is gravy because they can pull all that sound without a lot of this, you know moving faders and pushing this. You hear a lot of those kinds of recordings where it's artificially enhanced.

MR: Did you learn that from books?

JL: No. I learned that from talking with guys like Bill Holman and Larry Wilcox and you name it, and Mancini. The books, arranging books don't exist. There are orchestration books. They teach you how to voice. Voicing is not arranging. Voicing is just one aspect of arranging. It's just one thing. People talk about oh the secret voicings, voicings don't

mean crap unless you get a melody that warrants having that sound, that voicing. Gil Evans —

MR: I think there's some unsung orchestrators, like when I listen to "West Side Story" and you look like okay who orchestrated this, because it was brilliantly done, at least in my opinion. So I suppose that's a whole other part of the music business, being an orchestrator.

JL: It really is. There's an orchestrator named Kim Scharnberg who went to Eastman with Maria I believe. He could tell you some stories. But generally, I forgot the orchestrator for — a major orchestrator for "West Side Story," anyway, those guys were really the backbone. Because the composer, I did some work for Marvin Hamlisch. And this guy, I mean he had two or three lines that — well anyway the orchestrator would take this jumble and make it into something important. I orchestrated on "A Chorus Line" for part of that show, and the stuff I was handed was awful, just awful. But you make it work, you make it work, you know that they must have been in a hurry or whatever, lack of talent or skill, and you make it full. Boy the orchestrator, talk to any film composer. If they didn't have a real orchestrator, forget it. You know I'm dropping names, but I'll leave that alone, but a certain major composer did some films in Hollywood, and he was the real composer. And so he went to the producers and they said, "Oh no, we have orchestrators do all that stuff, just give me some melodies and go away." And well anyway, and he told that story and he was just aghast. The orchestrators in Hollywood are really the composers. Put it that way. I'm not talking out of school, everyone knows that. Everyone in the music business knows that.

MR: So you based most of your life on the fact that you had this urge, you heard something in your head, you wrote it down and you waited for someone to play it.

JL: Yeah.

MR: There's nothing like hearing the chart the first time, is there?

JL: It's amazing. Mancini told me that no matter how many times that he's written for orchestra or big band or films or whatever, he always got nervous when he got on that podium to hear what it really sounded like. He knew what it was going to sound like, but to hear, to have that experience. It's great. You say wow, this is fantastic. And of course now I have to spend my money to hear it played because there are no big bands to write for anymore.

MR: Right. Get your own band.

JL: Yeah well that's it. You know that's what prompted me in 2004 I did that "Walk on the Wild Side" CD. I figured I wrote for everybody else, now I'm going to write for me. You know I'm going to write for me and have something out there with my name on it finally. I didn't mind being second fiddle to the leader of the band, not at all. But there was no

place to go with my music, I mean, really. And writing for publishing or for the educational field, that's not the same and you don't really get to hear it played.

MR: Um hum. Just to wrap up here, we've been going for about an hour. Fascinating stuff. The plop-plop-fizz-fizz, when I saw that in something I read about you I went back and I looked, because I remember that from when I was a kid, with Speedy Alka-Seltzer. Now that morphed into something else with Sammy Davis? Is that correct?

JL: Well there was a man by the name of Tom Dawes who actually wrote the melody. He wrote that theme for the advertising agency. He was in some rock band, I can't remember. But they had so many different versions of that and when Bayer Corporation bought, they bought Alka-Seltzer, they wanted to reach another market, which would be the African-American market. They didn't have any exposure in that area. So they figured who's the most important TV personality, black TV personality, Sammy Davis. He was on Johnny Carson all the time. So they got him to do it. So we had that particular run of thought, which was Sammy Davis Junior.

MR: Doing a swing version of it?

JL: I did. They wanted a Woody Herman type version, swing version and they wanted a rock version. And I did both. I did them in New York. I had Ron Carter on bass. I had my brother Joe on drums. I think it was Harold Danko on piano, because he and Joe had an apartment together. But anyway it was a full orchestra, it was great. And we had a Sammy Davis sound-alike scratch vocal guy and then Sammy was in Las Vegas at Caesar's so I did everything in New York and we did a scratch-vocal.

MR: I see. Behind the scenes. Fascinating. Did you ever get a call to do a jingle that you just said I can't do this.

JL: Yeah. A couple. I won't elaborate, but there were a couple I just couldn't put my name on. I couldn't put my soul into it, no.

MR: Did you ever get one that you said I can't do this and then your musical mind started working despite yourself?

JL: I might have. I really can't remember. It might have but it's possible. I've had that happen with singers when I arrange for singers or not arrange for singers and after the fact I'd say you know I could have done this, I could have done that. But really, for singers, they're a different breed. But that's easy work because the melody is covered. All you have to do is just support that singer. Yeah, the easiest writing you'll ever get in your life is when the producer or the director or whoever says, "I want a big band chart and I want it in the key of F because the singer sings it that way, and I want you to modulate halfway through for a tenor solo." They tell you exactly what you want, you don't have to work, it's done. But when they say, you know I got a grant one time and I

could write anything I want. Total freedom. What do you do? There was no directive. So that's the hardest. That's really the hard part.

MR: Too many choices.

JL: Too many choices, exactly. Give me some restrictions. Give me a stop sign, give me a caution light, give me something.

MR: Well I'll wrap up with a basic non-music question. How are you feeling about the state of our country?

JL: Well it's a little bit better. I mean I see things in a positive light now. Quite honestly, and I'll be political, if this Trump guy had had another four years Marie and I would be out of the country. We would be gone. I mean honestly, I would be probably back in Italy. I don't know. But that was really strong on my mind because I don't think I could have seen the country deteriorate like that and live in it.

MR: Okay. Anything that you'd like to add that I haven't asked about?

JL: Well I know that the family history, some of it is in Joe's book. You know Joe wrote a book on Bill Evans that's coming out in September, his time with Bill Evans. And I heard you talk to Pat about education. And if there's an education gene then we must have it because our paternal grandfather, excuse me, he was able to finish three grades of school before he got indentured to a baron. And it was really rough work and he died prematurely because of it. He would play with the baron's children after church on Sunday because he wasn't that much older, and he taught them how to read. I don't know if he taught them how to write but he taught them how to read. And the baron was so knocked out because he was illiterate. Most of the nobility were illiterate and the church kind of ran their affairs for them, that he excused the indentured loan and gave my grandfather a piece of land to work on shares, to sharecrop. And then my father became a teacher, all three of us became teachers, my two sons are teachers. So there's got to be some sort of gene there that's, you know, passing that on. You have to really like it. You really have to love it and of course know what you're teaching. Know the subject.

MR: And that dated back to Sicily, that story you started?

JL: Yeah. Yeah my grandfather, he was indentured, and again, my father, once he finally got that piece — you couldn't own land in Sicily or Italy until Mussolini. Nobody could own land except the nobility. So once he was excused, see what happened, you know children are a commodity. There was no work for people. The children were a commodity. If you have a lot of children and the baron comes to you saying I need a worker, I'll give you 500 lire and then you pay me back and you have your kid back. That's the way it worked. And of course you never could find the 500 lire again, if you took it. And so and my grandfather only had one eye so he's probably the most compromised of the family and so he was — and they probably figured this is a way for him to make a living or have a

life. But my father remembers when he was a little boy working out in the field with my grandfather. They had this piece of land and they would do the wheat and — so but the teaching was always there. I think it dates back at least to my grandfather. Yeah.

MR: Fascinating. Well I want to thank you for joining me today and I wish you the best of luck with your upcoming recording.

JL: Thank you.

MR: And I look forward to hearing it.

JL: I'm looking forward to hearing it too. You know this dry period during the pandemic has made me really antsy and wanting to get things done. Of course I've had time to look at the parts and correct the mistakes. So there is some positive thing coming out of this.

MR: Yeah. Excellent. Well thanks a lot for your time today.

JL: Thank you, Monk, for having me. I really enjoyed it. I talk too much.

MR: I like it.